

POSTPARTUM DEPRESSION (PPD)

Be aware of the risk factors and warning signs of PPD and don't hesitate to seek support. Speak to someone as soon as you notice any of the warning signs.

Risk factors

The risk factors listed below make it more likely you will suffer with PPD. If any of them apply to you, take steps to reduce your chances of developing the condition; it's easier to take preventative action than to motivate yourself to find help once you are depressed.

- » You have been depressed before or during your pregnancy.
- » You had a traumatic delivery.
- » You had a recent stressful event, such as a bereavement.
- » You generally have little support.



Warning signs

- » You find it hard to sleep, have fitful sleep, or wake too early feeling anxious.
- » You feel low-level anxiety, or perhaps feel very anxious and suffer from panic attacks.
- » You feel irritable and lack concentration.
- » You struggle to feel enjoyment or pleasure in life, and lack humor.
- » You feel guilty and generally miserable.
- » Your appetite is poor, or you overeat.
- » You feel lethargic, tired, and unmotivated, and you aren't managing to take care of yourself properly.
- » You feel isolated.
- » You have little interest in your baby.



Support

Talk to your partner, or other loved ones, and consult your doctor if you experience any of the warning signs more than a week after the birth. Don't ignore these feelings since they are easily treatable—if left they can affect your relationship with your baby, partner, and others.

If you have suffered from depression before, the symptoms will feel familiar, although with PPD there is the added factor of how your illness impacts your baby and your relationship with him. Getting help may make all the difference in your experience of motherhood.



GETTING HELP

There is help available to treat PPD, so make an appointment to see your doctor as soon as possible.

Many women recover from PPD without treatment, but up to a quarter of women still have PPD after a year. In this time, their relationship with their baby will have suffered, which might affect the baby's social development.

Your doctor may refer you for talking therapy, prescribe antidepressant medication, or do both. Antidepressants may help to lift your mood to enable

you to explore the root causes of your depression. There are antidepressants that are compatible with breast-feeding. Antidepressants take around two weeks to start working and need to be taken for six months to deal with the depression effectively.

Your thyroid function may be tested, since levels of the hormone thyroid can drop after pregnancy, which can cause some of the symptoms of depression.

